speeches that referred constantly to the fears of colonialism and neocolonialism, the desire for economic autarky and aversion to the cold war blocs.

Like Nehru, Indira also tried, but failed, to reconcile India's claims to moral ascendancy with the realities of global power politics. According to Mansingh, Indira remained preoccupied with the question, 'how to be strong enough to prevent encroachment on national interests by outside powers and yet avoid intimidating small neighbouring states by an increase of power'. It did not help that there was disagreement on the proper status of India in the world.

'Was India a small power to be treated as a pawn in international politics because of its low per capita income?' Mansingh asked. That was not the only fully unanswered question though. 'Was India a middle power by virtue of its size, capability and the middle position it occupied between competing blocs? Was India a regional power because of its strategic location and historic position in southern Asia? Or was India an emergent great power in aspiration and perhaps in fact?'[94] Some of these questions facing Indira still remain issues in India's foreign policy debate.

Indira tilted the scales of the 'morality or power' debate in favour of power. She also had a lasting impact on the organizational conduct of foreign policy. Indira followed Shastri's lead rather than her father's tradition by appointing a cabinet member as minister for external affairs. Subsequently, all prime ministers, with the exception of Inder Kumar Gujral, always appointed an external affairs minister and, if needed, held the portfolio themselves only for short periods of time. (Gujral, who served as prime minister briefly in 1997–98, saw himself in Nehru's mould and tried to run foreign policy directly from the Prime Minister's Office.) The influence of prime ministers on foreign policy remained profound even in the presence of a cabinet minister wielding the external affairs portfolio.

ECLIPSE OF COLD WAR POLITICS